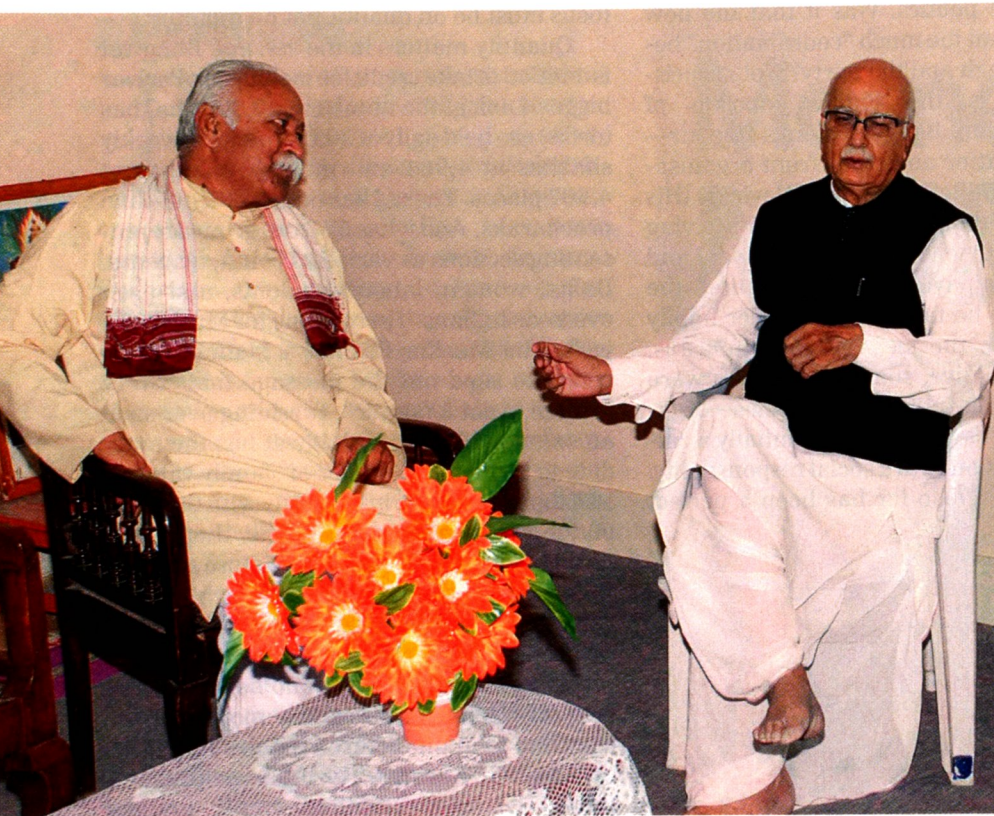




BHAGWAT WITH ADVANI

ing the importance of caste leaders in expanding the RSS' base. He doesn't make a virtue out of rigidity masquerading as consistency. Following Advani's controversial statement on "secular" Jinnah, Bhagwat was the first to tell the RSS top brass that they should take on the BJP leader. Three years later, the same Bhagwat realised that there was no better alternative than Advani to lead the BJP. So he himself went to meet Advani to announce that he was once again acceptable to the RSS.

A great admirer of Gandhi, he was the one who took the initiative in bringing Scheduled Castes and Tribes into the RSS fold. In one of the speeches he delivered after becoming the general secretary, he didn't mention the name of Hindutva icon Veer Savarkar even once but Gandhi was a recurring hero. An agitated Savarkar supporter went to Bhagwat and complained. Bhagwat, always polite, apologised first and then took on the challenger: "But tell me whether you appreciate Gandhi's contribution to society despite his mistakes." The challenger just walked away in silence, most likely as a wiser man. And his soon-to-be-launched programme called Gau-Gram Sankarshan Yatra (a cow-protection journey across the villages) too is inspired by Gandhi.

The Bhagwat Effect

- A non-interventionist, Bhagwat lets BJP and VHP leaders manage their affairs so that the RSS will not be blamed for their failures. Unlike Sudarshan, he has never been a political coordinator.
- A smart networker, he has initiated dialogue with other spiritual leaders like Sri Sri Ravi Shankar and Baba Ramdev whom he has accepted as important members of the wider Hindu Family. Accepts that there is no singular way of championing the Hindu cause.
- As general secretary, he promoted young volunteers at every level. The average age of pracharaks at district level has been reduced from 50 to 35-40 and those above 70 have been withdrawn from the field.
- He has never made a hate speech or attacked other religions.
- He prefers powerpoint presentations at important meetings.

Bhagwat, a *Reader's Digest* junkie and a regular watcher of History and National Geographic channels, ended his speech in Nagpur with a call for facing up to new challenges: "Let all of us strive to expand and consolidate still further our already existing nationwide network to enable our society to effectively respond to all the challenges it is facing, by adopting appropriate strategies and techniques". What are Bhagwat's strategies and techniques to keep RSS relevant as a cultural organisation? He certainly requires techniques other than powerpoint presentations (of which he is a new convert) and the emphasis on youth power (of which he is a tireless promoter). He needs a message that is in tune with the ideas and aspirations of 21st Century India where a brotherhood based on religion still evokes fear, no matter what the religion is called. "You can change everything, except our core belief in a Hindu Rashtra", he says. If such a civilisational definition of India makes some Indians the excluded others, the challenges of the man who aspires to be the moderniser become all the more daunting. It also provides Mohanrao Bhagwat an opportunity to become the Great Reconciler. *with Shyamal Yadav and Uday Mahurkar*